

Digital Arts and Sciences

Final Project – Assignment Details

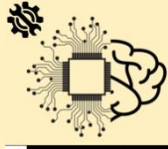
Final Project – Spring 2026

"Don't cry because it's over, smile because it happened." -Dr. Seuss

"Never gonna give you up. Never gonna let you go." -Dr. Astley

Overview

Item	Details
Type	Teams (typically 5-6 students) which were set at the beginning of the course
Weight	45% of the overall course grade
Due	1. Week 14: Project conference (ungraded) 2. Artifact submission: Sunday June 14, 11:59pm 3. Project exhibition: Wednesday June 17, 10:00am – 12:00pm
Grading	Weighted rubric with peer evaluation adjustment (see below)
Submission	Canvas: flexible format (see Deliverables)
AI Level	Level 4: Full AI use (primarily to help creatively exhibit your project using AI-assisted coding tools)

Level	Description	Possible Evidence/Documentation (at the instructor's discretion, this or other evidence may be requested)
Level 4: Full AI use  4 FULL AI	AI may be used to complete any elements of the task, with students directing AI to achieve the assessment goals. Assessments at this level may also require engagement with AI to achieve goals and solve problems. You may use AI extensively throughout your work as you wish, particularly as a tool to facilitate the exhibition of your project. Focus on directing AI to achieve your goals while demonstrating critical thinking.	Written or recorded explanation of the strategy used to direct AI, including decision-making processes. Portfolio showcasing the evolution of the work, from AI-generated content to final product and a reflection of the strengths, weaknesses, biases of the AI tool(s), and the effectiveness of the AI-human process.

NEW: I created the [“Digital Human Helper”](#) chatbot to help you brainstorm/refine possible topics for your project. Although it's [hopefully] not a replacement for Ms. Linh and I, I hope it helps your team in the early stages of ideation.

Purpose

Over the semester, you've learned to digitize texts, analyze them computationally, create spatial narratives (story mapping), record soundscapes and oral histories, and preserve physical artifacts through photogrammetry and Gaussian splatting. Now, your team will combine at least two of these methods together into a single, original, impactful digital humanities project.

The goal is not just to demonstrate technical skills, but to use digital humanities methods to tell a story that matters, such as preserving, interpreting, or sharing something about Vietnamese cultural heritage, communities, languages, people, or landscapes that deserves attention. Remember, a key ethos of DH is giving a voice to the underrepresented.

Your project will culminate in a public exhibition where visitors (including invited guests) will explore your work. Think of this project as creating something for an audience beyond the classroom, not just an assignment.

By completing this project, you will:

- Synthesize multiple DH methods covered in the course into a cohesive, original project
- Create an engaging exhibit to help a non-specialist audience engage with a culturally significant topic
- Design an interactive digital experience for a public audience
- Collaborate effectively as a team to produce a polished, exhibition-ready product
- Direct AI tools strategically to achieve complex project goals, especially in the presentation of the deliverables

What you will create

Your team will create an interactive (i.e. the visitors will interact with your project) digital experience that **combines at least two DH methods from the course into a unified project**. This digital experience will be your primary deliverable which visitors will engage with at the exhibition and what you will submit for grading.

It could be hosted on an “off-the-shelf” platform, or you can use AI-assisted coding tools to create your own (ex. a website) if you prefer. Or a combination of both.

The digital experience should be interactive: a visitor with no prior knowledge should be able to explore it and understand why it matters, and what they are experiencing.

Topic

Your project should align with the spirit of digital humanities: using digital tools to explore, preserve, interpret, or share cultural knowledge. The best projects will be meaningful, impactful, and give voice to people, places, or communities that deserve attention. Shining a light in the darkness. Giving a voice to the voiceless. Your stuffed Shopee Shrimp is meaningful but think of the bigger picture.

Your topic will most likely relate to Vietnam, given that we are all based here and many methods (soundscape recording, oral histories, document/artifact/environmental scanning, etc.) require physical access to places and people. Other topics are possible with my approval at the project conference.

Some examples to spark ideas:

- Documenting a disappearing craft or tradition through oral history + 3D scanning.
- Mapping the sonic and spatial character of a neighborhood through soundscapes + story mapping. Maybe throw in an oral history to include the people of that neighborhood?
- Digitizing and analyzing a collection of historical Vietnamese texts, presented through an interactive website
- Preserving a lesser-known heritage site through 3D scanning + ambient sound, told through a story map
- Exploring how a community’s relationship with a place has changed over time, using multiple methods to capture different dimensions
- Any other project that meaningfully combines DH methods to explore cultural questions

What makes a strong topic: A clear purpose or question driving the project. Not just “here are some interesting things” but a meaningful inquiry. Think about who benefits from this project existing. What story would be lost without it? What community or heritage does it serve?

DH methods

Your project must integrate at least two of the following methods that we covered in the course:

1. **Text digitization** (OCR, HTR, scanning). Although the MP1 scanning equipment is not on GearBank, contact me if you want to borrow it.
2. **Computational text analysis** (corpus linguistics, Voyant Tools, Sketch Engine, pattern analysis)
3. **Story mapping / spatial narrative** (StoryMapJS, [ArcGIS StoryMaps](#) or similar).
- **Update 27/5:** In its most basic form, story mapping (for example pinning locations on StoryMapJS + adding text/sound/video) is more of a medium than a technique. It is *possible* to augment a basic pin + content to make it more significant, but I would encourage you to think of story mapping more like a platform than a technique, unless you somehow go beyond pin + content. If your heart is set on story mapping, I would encourage you to combine two other methods + story mapping for the final project. But if in doubt, please contact me to clarify.
4. **Sound** (soundscapes, oral histories)
5. **3D digitization** (photogrammetry, Gaussian splatting)

Important: The methods you use should be genuinely integrated together to tell a richer story than either could tell alone. Two random methods bundled together is not true integration. A project that uses photogrammetry to scan a market stall and records the vendor’s oral history, woven into a spatial narrative about the market’s cultural significance: chef’s kiss 🥰👉! Now that’s integration.

Tools

You may use any tools appropriate to your project, including all tools covered in the course. I will share some options between now and the end of the course, including in our last lesson on June 3/4.

Although there are many free “off the shelf” websites to exhibit projects like this (think of a virtual museum), this is a Level 4 (Full AI Use) assignment, so AI tools are permitted for building your website and any interactive features. For the website/interactive experience, options include (but are not limited to): Vercel v0, Lovable, Replit, Bolt.new, Wix, WordPress, or any platform that lets you create a polished, accessible website. Choose whatever works best for your project.

Equipment: Specialized equipment is available through [GearBank](#), including field recorders, binaural microphones, a 360 degree camera, wireless microphones, light tents/softbox lights, and other accessories. Reserve early: equipment is shared across sections.

Remember, we also have the VinUni Podcast Studio on the 2nd floor of the library which you can book (Semi-Pro studio). Mr. Kep from the library can support you with the Rodecaster Pro 2 mixer and microphones.

A Note on Scope

Don't overwork yourselves! This is a team project with 5-6 people. Distribute the work equitably, use each other's strengths, and focus on quality over quantity. A focused, polished project with two well-integrated methods is far better than an unfocused project that tries to incorporate everything. Enjoy the process: you are creating something **real** for a real audience. That should be exciting, not stressful! ^ ^

Grading

Pay attention: this may be different than other projects you've done.

The final project is worth **45%** of your course grade, divided into two graded components **plus a peer evaluation mechanism**:

A. Digital Experience Artifact (35%)

Your submitted website/experience, graded on the weighted rubric below. **Each team member's grade for this 35% component is individually adjusted by a peer evaluation multiplier (see C below).**

B. Exhibition (10%)

Your presentation at the public exhibition. You will be graded on how effectively you communicate your project's significance, engage visitors, and answer questions.

C. Peer Evaluation Multiplier

After the exhibition, each team member will complete a confidential peer evaluation rating their teammates' contributions to the project. These ratings are converted into an individual multiplier applied to each student's 35% project grade. The multiplier is capped at $\pm 15\%$, meaning your individual product grade can be adjusted up or down by a maximum of 15% based on your peers' assessment of your contributions.

How the Peer Evaluation Multiplier Works

After the exhibition, you will rate each of your teammates on behavioral criteria including quality of contribution, reliability, collaboration, and initiative. Ratings are averaged for each student and normalized against the team mean to produce a multiplier.

Example: If your team's product receives a group score of 85% for the 35% component of the project:

Student	Peer Multiplier	Group Score	Adjusted Score
Student A	1.10	85%	93.5%
Student B	1.05	85%	89.25%
Student B	1.00	85%	85%
Student C	0.95	85%	80.75%
Student D	0.88	85%	74.8%

Key details:

- The multiplier is capped at $\pm 15\%$. No student can be adjusted more than this, regardless of ratings.
- With 5 raters per student, a single outlier rating has limited impact. The system smooths out individual bias.
- **Behavioral criteria** are used (not generic "rate 1–5" scales). You will rate specific behaviors like meeting deadlines, contributing quality work, and supporting teammates.
- We will do training before the final rating so you understand the process and the tool.
- Written justification is required for ratings at the extremes. If you rate a teammate very high or very low, you must explain why.

Why this system? Team projects work best when everyone contributes equitably. The multiplier ensures that individual effort is recognized and that the grade you receive reflects the work each member actually did. Research shows that peer evaluation systems improve both team performance and students' perceptions of fairness in group work.

Conference with Prof. Dan (ungraded)

In Week 14 (or before), each team will meet with me for a 15-minute conference to pitch your project idea, receive feedback, and get approval to proceed. This is a two-way discussion, not a formal presentation. Come prepared with ideas for your topic, your planned methods, and a rough vision for the final product.

The conference is ungraded, but it is required. You must receive approval (or “revise and resubmit” feedback) before proceeding with your project.

Deliverables

Your submission should include:

- 1. Your final artifact(s).** The format is flexible so be creative. Ask me if you're unsure.
- 2. Any supplementary materials (if applicable):** companion websites, consent forms, additional documentation, or other artifacts that are part of your project.
- 3. Documentation of AI use cover sheet:** Remember, this is a Level 4 assignment so there is nothing to hide or be ashamed of by using AI! I am just interested in how you used it and what worked/didn't work.

Submit on Canvas by the deadline. The format is flexible:

- If submitting file(s): upload the file(s) to the Canvas submission. If submitting multiple files, remember to upload all files to the Canvas assignment.
- If submitting a link (website, interactive tool, etc.): paste the URL in the Canvas text entry box and ensure the link is accessible.
- Regardless of format, make sure your tier declaration and AI documentation are clearly included in the submission comment or attached in the submission file(s).

Digital Arts & Sciences: Final Project (Product – 35%)

Weight	Category	Exemplary	Advanced	Proficient	Developing	Emergent
25%	DH Methods: Execution & Integration	Multiple DH methods are executed with high competence and genuinely integrated to produce insights neither could alone. Method choices are clearly justified by the project's purpose.	Multiple DH methods are well-executed and work together effectively. Integration is clear with minor missed opportunities for deeper connection.	At least two DH methods are used competently. Some integration is present, but the methods may feel somewhat separate rather than unified.	Two methods are attempted but execution is weak in one or both. Methods feel disconnected or forced together.	Fewer than two methods are used, or methods are poorly executed with no meaningful integration.
20%	Research Depth & Cultural Significance	The project demonstrates deep, genuine engagement with its subject. Research goes well beyond surface-level information. The cultural significance is compelling and clearly articulated.	Strong research and/or meaningful engagement with the subject. Cultural significance is well-articulated with only minor gaps.	Adequate depth in the project, but somewhat superficial. Some cultural significance is evident but could be deeper or more clearly communicated.	Research is superficial or relies heavily on easily available information. The project's cultural significance is unclear.	Minimal research evident. No meaningful cultural or scholarly significance is communicated.
20%	Narrative & Storytelling	The project tells a compelling, coherent story with a clear purpose. The narrative is well-structured and engaging. The audience understands why this project matters.	The narrative is clear and engaging with a purposeful structure. Minor improvements could strengthen the storytelling.	A narrative is present and followable. Structure is adequate but may lack a compelling focus or emotional engagement.	The narrative is fragmented or unclear. The project feels more like a collection of elements than a coherent story.	No discernible narrative structure. The project lacks purpose or direction.
20%	Design & User Experience	The website or experience is visually polished, intuitive to navigate, and enhances the content. Design choices are intentional and serve the narrative. Ready for public exhibition.	The website / experience is well-designed and easy to navigate. Minor design improvements could enhance the user experience.	The website / experience is functional and readable. Design is adequate but unremarkable or inconsistent in places.	The website / experience has significant usability issues or poor design choices that detract from the content.	The website is non-functional, inaccessible, or so poorly designed that the content cannot be meaningfully engaged with.
15%	Process Documentation & AI Use	Thorough documentation of the project process, including key decisions and challenges. AI use is documented with critical, insightful reflection on what worked and what didn't.	Good process documentation and thoughtful AI use reflection. Some critical evaluation of AI outputs is present.	Process is documented and AI use is acknowledged. Reflection is present but remains surface-level.	Documentation is incomplete or vague. AI use is mentioned but not meaningfully reflected upon.	Minimal or no documentation. AI use is not addressed or is dismissed.

Notes:

- The top scoring category does not denote perfection but rather shows excellence which is above the expectations of this category.
- A zero may be awarded if the task is incomplete or significantly below expectations.
- In the event of plagiarism or AI misuse, penalties will be applied according to the VinUniversity academic integrity policy.

Digital Arts & Sciences: Final Project (Exhibition – 10%)

Weight	Category	Exemplary	Advanced	Proficient	Developing	Emergent
60%	Presentation & Communication	The team communicates the project's significance with clarity, enthusiasm, and depth. All members are able to speak confidently about the project. The booth or display is inviting and professional.	The team communicates the project well and most members speak with clarity and confidence. The display is organized and engaging.	The team presents the project adequately. Some members may struggle to articulate the project's significance. The display is functional but not engaging/professional.	The team struggles to communicate the project's significance clearly. The display is disorganized or incomplete.	The team is unprepared. No meaningful communication of the project's purpose or significance.
40%	Visitor Engagement & Q&A	Team members proactively engage visitors and answer questions with depth, demonstrating strong understanding of all aspects of the project, not just their own contribution.	Team members engage visitors and answer most questions well, demonstrating good understanding of the project as a whole.	Team members respond to visitors' questions but engagement is mostly reactive. Understanding may be limited to individual contributions.	Team members provide minimal engagement with visitors. Answers to questions are vague or reveal limited understanding.	Team members do not engage with visitors or cannot answer basic questions about the project.

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